

WE'VE PLAYED A LOT OF VIDEO GAMES AND WE'VE LEARNT A LOT FROM THEM TOO. WE COULD ACTUALLY WRITE AN ENTIRE ARTICLE JUST ABOUT THE THINGS YOU COULD LEARN FROM VIDEOGAMES (WE ACTUALLY HAVE ALREADY WRITTEN ONE FOR THAT MATTER) BUT FOR THE PURPOSES OF THIS ARTICLE, WE'RE JUST GOING TO TOUCH ON ONE OF THEM. HISTORY!

Now when we say history, here we're not talking about the history of gaming but rather the history in gaming. Videogames are a powerful storytelling tool and by using history as a setting they're effectively teaching us more about it. We've got games like Total War and Sengoku: Way of the Warrior, which put us in charge of famous historical campaigns as we lead our troops and nation and relive history itself. We've got games like the Civilization franchise which attempts to condense the entirety of history for us to enjoy. Let's not forget age-old classics like Age of Empires which for many of us would have been the very first historically-based strategy game we played. Then there's the plethora of FPS or shooter games based on and during World War II. And now with the Battlefield I reveal, maybe we'll start seeing a whole lot more games revolving around World War I as well.

It's great, isn't it? Why waste time studying history in school when you could just play some games and learn all about history from them, right? Hmm, not quite. Now usually we'd be the first to jump on the "videogames are better at teaching history than teachers" bandwagon but maybe let's take a few steps back and ask ourselves the question, are they really? We don't mean to nitpick about how plastic bags shouldn't have existed in

Wolfenstein or how door knobs weren't invented yet in Assassin's Creed: Unity. Game developers are allowed to take such liberties when it comes to the plot of their games. After all, the success of their games depends on how much we, as the player, enjoy it.

Going back to Assassin's Creed: Unity as an example, the game is based around the French Revolution. Those of you who are familiar with the topic would know that the French Revolution happened over a course of several years, but the game shortens this time down considerably, and it's understandable as to why they would do so. The Assassin's Creed franchise is an excellent example of history being used in gaming. The games feature several prominent historical figures and places and we actually get to participate in several monumental moments in history. We also get a glimpse at the functioning of the machinery and the society of the time. Now here's the important bit, those of us who do have a slight background in history should be able to point out how something or some person is out of place, but not everyone is well-read when it comes to topics like history. Those who do play the game are satisfied with the knowledge they get from it, which unfortunately could be inaccurate. Now if we had to touch historical inaccuracies in every game

released to date... it'll take forever, so let's just touch a few prominent titles.

Age of Empires

This was the game that lit the fires of historical interest in many of us. If you've played this game then you know that there are campaigns and such throughout the game but they're fairly straightforward. The game gives you set of objectives that you need to complete and you're free to go about them in any way or sequence you please unless they specifically state otherwise. This formula has pretty much remained the same for most games of the genre. While the AoE games follow actual events in history, the way they play out is very different from what actually happens. Civilizations as diverse as the Japanese and the Aztec sharing the same units is also a tad absurd. Of course, we don't need to tell you that there's no way a stone structure will crumble and catch fire when a long swordsman whacks at it with his sword. But this is understood, the game still did a good job of educating people about the various playable factions and civilizations. Rather than teaching us about history itself, Age of Empires can be seen as the transition of man through the ages. From the Stone Age to the Bronze Age and then to the Iron Age. The technological developments, from the fire to the wheel. So even though we're not